

Theological method in "Evangelii Gaudium": A dialogue with Bernard Lonergan and Robert Doran

Author(s): Gerard Whelan

Source: *Gregorianum*, Vol. 96, No. 1 (2015), pp. 51-75

Published by: Edizioni Studium srl

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/24433497>

Accessed: 10-07-2026 16:24 UTC

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at <https://about.jstor.org/terms>



JSTOR

Edizioni Studium srl is collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to *Gregorianum*

Theological method in *Evangelii Gaudium*

A dialogue with Bernard Lonergan and Robert Doran

While enthusiasm for Pope Francis and his apostolic exhortation, *Evangelii Gaudium*, is evident in the world media, one can occasionally hear the comment: «his message is primarily pastoral and not academic». This article offers a reflection on how in one academic circle, at least, his statements and writings are considered to have the highest significance. At a recent graduation ceremony of theology students the following reflection was offered by a Lonergan scholar:

This is a wonderful time in the life of the Church to offer encouragement to a group of people graduating with degrees in theology [...] as the Church is renewed by the Holy Spirit and in the spirit of Pope Francis. For I believe that we are about to be part of the emergence of a theological atmosphere in the Church that can and will be similar to that which was experienced by people of my generation in the wake of the Second Vatican Council¹.

In this article I explore areas of compatibility between the teaching of Pope Francis and the thought on theological method of Bernard Lonergan, especially as interpreted by Robert Doran, the person who made this quoted statement.

I. POPE FRANCIS AND INDUCTIVE THEOLOGY

This section touches on three themes that are more comprehensively outlined by Juan Carlos Scannone and Carlos Galli in this current issue of the

¹ R. Doran, editor of the Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan (CWL), commencement address to St. Michael's College, Toronto, November 2013 (unpublished). Accessed in 09.2014 at: stmikes.utoronto.ca/convocation/usmc/doc/ConvocationAddress_Nov2_2013_R.Doran.pdf.

Gregorianum: the characteristics of the Argentinian, post-Vatican II, «theology of the people»; the influence of this theology on the series of assemblies of bishops of Latin America that occurred, 1968-2007; and the fact that close parallels exist between the most recent of these assemblies, in *Aparecida* 2007, and *Evangelii Gaudium*. On each of these themes, I highlight points that are particularly relevant for my argument in subsequent sections: that the thought of Lonergan and Doran can provide explanatory foundations for much of what both a theology of the People and Pope Francis are trying to achieve.

1. *A Theology of the People*

Juan Carlos Scannone's article, «Papa Francesco e la teologia del popolo» is an important contribution to helping theologians from around the world to understand the «intellectual roots of Pope Francis»². In explaining the Argentinian «theology of the people», Scannone first locates it within the broader movement of liberation theology³, suggesting that, from the late 1960s onwards, all expressions of this theology at held least two characteristics in common: they promoted a «preferential option for the poor»; and they adopted an «inductive» method of «See, Judge, Act»⁴. Next, he suggests that a significant difference existed between Argentinian theology and the other three kinds of liberation theology, with the former placing a stress on questions of culture, and the positive aspects of popular piety, that was not found in other strains of liberation theology. The significance of this difference was highlighted by the Uruguayan Jesuit theologian, Juan Luis Segundo, who was sharply critical of the emerging Argentinian theology. In fact he coined the term «theology of the people» as a pejorative term. Scannone points out that the Peruvian theologian, Gustavo Gutierrez, took a more tolerant approach to this difference, but still distinguished between the «socio-cultural mediation» of Argentinian theologians and the «socio-economic mediation» of the others, such as himself⁵.

² J.C. SCANNONE, «Papa Francesco e la teologia del popolo», *La Civiltà Cattolica* 165 (2014) I 571-590. In this section I also rely on unpublished talks and round-table discussions from a conference run jointly by publishers of *La Civiltà Cattolica* and the Pontifical Gregorian University: «Le radici intellettuali di Papa Francesco. Un anno di Pontificato» (March 27-28, 2014), in which Scannone took part.

³ J.C. SCANNONE, «Papa Francesco e la teologia del popolo» (cf. nt. 2), 576.

⁴ Joseph Cardijn founded the movement «Young Christian Workers» in Belgium in the early twentieth century: see E. LANGDALE, ed., *Joseph Cardijn. Challenge To Action*, Chicago (IL) 1955. Pope John XXIII expresses approval of this pastoral method in *Mater et Magistra* 236 (15 May 1961). While not explicitly referring to this method, *Gaudium et Spes* adopts it.

⁵ Segundo accused the Argentinian theologians of the people of indulging in «verbal terrorism» and suggested that the poor should be understood in terms of the Marxist notion of

2. *Argentinian Theology and CELAM*

Various commentators suggest that a kind of competition for influence grew up between the different kinds of liberation theology in the decades following Vatican II, above all expressed in the plenary assemblies of the national conferences of Latin American bishops, known as CELAM conferences. Scannone suggest that the influence of a theology of the people was little in the Medellín conference of 1968, but that it increased considerably by the time of Puebla, in 1979. He explains this in terms of the support for a theology of the people by Pope Paul VI and by the Pope's including themes from this theology in his apostolic exhortation, *Evangelii Nuntiandi* (1975)⁶.

Scannone deals somewhat discreetly with subsequent developments, under the pontificate of Pope John Paul II, which are described in more dramatic terms by other commentators⁷. During the CELAM meeting at Santo Domingo in 1992 the preparatory document that had been prepared for the assembly was withdrawn and a document provided by the Vatican was offered in its place. This document differed in major ways from the final documents issues by previous assemblies. Above all it avoided referring to or employing the method of «See, Judge, Act». Rather, it employed a deductive approach of applying universal principles to the Latin American context⁸. Some commentators at the time suggested that this constituted a definitive rejection of liberation theology in Latin America.

«proletariat» whose culture is primarily that of the «false consciousness» of the ruling class, J.L. SEGUNDO, *The Liberation of Theology*, New York 1976, 196-200.

⁶ Pope Paul VI states: «Between evangelization and human advancement — development and liberation — there are in fact profound links», and adds «what matters is to evangelize man's culture and cultures» (*Evangelii Nuntiandi* 20.31). Scannone suggests the Argentinian Cardinal Eduardo Pironio of Argentina, a personal friend of Pope Paul VI and future Prefect of the Pontifical Council of the Laity, helped to influence the apostolic exhortation (J.C. SCANNONE, «Papa Francesco e la teologia del popolo» [cf. nt. 2], 575-576).

⁷ See R. PELTON, «Medellín and Puebla, Dead or Alive?», in R. PELTON, ed., *Aparecida. Quo Vadis?*, Scranton (PA) 2008, 25-48; and J. MARINS, «Base Communities, a Return to Inductive Methodology», in *ibid.*, 93-99. In what follows, I also rely on an unpublished talk offered by Guzmán Carriquiry, Secretary of the Pontifical Council for Latin America, at the conference, mentioned above, «Le radici di Papa Francesco. Un anno di Pontificato», March 2014. See also M. ANTONELLI, «Da Medellín a Aparecida. Il caso Latino-Americana», in M. VERGOTTINI, *Concilio Vaticano II. Il «balzo innanzi» della teologia*, Milano 2012, 349-428.

⁸ The Santo Domingo document introduced the vocabulary of «New Evangelization», to magisterial teaching and associated this closely with preaching the contents of the *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, which was published in the same year, 1992. This emphasis would continue through to the pontificate of Pope Benedict VI, see for example *Porta Fidei* (2011), the *moto proprio* issued to announce the Year of Faith of 2012-2013. The complimentary «Note with Pastoral Recommendations for the Year of Faith» issued by the Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith in 2012 suggested that promoting the *Catechism of the Catholic Church* should be a central pastoral strategy of the year. See M. ANTONELLI, «Da Medellín a Aparecida» (cf. nt. 7), 368-373.

Commentators next suggest that a striking change of direction occurred once again in the CELAM conference held in Aparecida, in 2007. In an article entitled «Base Communities, a Return to Inductive Methodology», Jose Marins suggests that the vocabulary of liberation theology made a reappearance in Aparecida. He suggests that the final document offered an emphatic restatement of themes that had not been prominent since Puebla: the importance of a preferential option for the poor; and the value of an inductive method of pastoral decision-making based on steps of «See, Judge, Act»⁹. He suggests that, exhibiting an amnesia with regard to Santo Domingo, the Aparecida document proclaims its continuity with Medellín and Puebla:

In continuity with the previous general conferences of Latin American Bishops, this document utilizes the see-judge-act method [...] this method has been helpful for living our calling and mission in the church with more dedication and intensity. It has enriched theological and pastoral work¹⁰.

Commentators agree that Aparecida has a distinctively Argentinian theological tone¹¹.

3. *From a Theology of the People to Evangelii Gaudium*

Scannone offers a clear explanation of the central role that Cardinal Jorge Bergoglio played in the Aparecida conference, as chairman of the drafting committee for the final document, and of the close parallels between that document and *Evangelii Gaudium*. I would add that, unlike the Aparecida document, *Evangelii Gaudium* is noteworthy for its criticisms of certain attitudes and theological positions often taken up by the Church, above all those expressed in an abstract approach to theology and a centralized approach to Church governance. I suggest that on this issue Pope Francis is partly reflecting on his experience of the way in which the Holy See dealt with the bishops of Latin America in the 1990's. Consequently, I suggest that *Evangelii Gaudium* stands to papal teaching much as Aparecida stands to earlier teachings of the assemblies of Latin American Bishops: «a return to inductive theology».

⁹ J. MARINS, «Base Communities, a Return to Inductive Methodology» (cf. nt. 7), 93-99. It should be noted that while the notion of «An evangelical preferential option for the poor» had been preserved in the Santo Domingo document it receives more emphatic mention in Aparecida, which describes it as «One of the characteristics which identifies the features of the Latin American and Caribbean Church». *Aparecida Final Document*, § 391. The document is posted in a variety of translations on the world-wide web see: [accessed in 11.2014], directoriorcatolico.blogspot.it/2013/07/pdf-documento-document-aparecida-celam.html.

¹⁰ *Aparecida Final Document* (cf. nt. 9), § 19.

¹¹ See G. GUTIERREZ, «The Preferential Option for the Poor at Aparecida», in R. PELTON, ed., *Aparecida. Quo Vadis?* (cf. nt. 7), 71-92.

Scannone stresses the importance of Pope Francis's statement about «four priorities» that should guide Christians in their attempt to transform history. He suggests that Bergoglio had been developing his thinking on these priorities since his time as a Jesuit Provincial in Argentina and that, in fact, they represent part of Bergoglio's distinctive contribution to a theology of the people¹². I suggest that they capture the approach to theology that I am calling «inductive». I outline these four points because, as I explain in subsequent sections, I find them a valuable point of engagement with the thought of Lonergan and Doran.

The first priority is described as «Time is more important than space» and here Pope Francis emphasises the importance of patience in trying to address the «processes of people-building» (*E.G.*, 224). By contrast, he proposes the metaphor of «seeking space» to describe those who short-circuit the reflective process necessary for good policy-making and who insist on taking power for themselves, usually resulting in «anti-people» policies¹³. Pope Francis' second priority, «unity prevails over conflict», addresses the question of how to engage with the conflicts between persons and ideas that inevitably arise in community building. He counsels that we should neither deny the reality of conflict nor «become its prisoner» but rather we should try to «face conflict head on, to resolve it and to make it a link in the chain of a new process» [227]. The third priority is entitled «realities are more important than ideas», constitutes yet another criticism of deductivist approaches to knowing: «Ideas — conceptual elaborations — are at the service of communication, understanding, and praxis» [232]. The fourth and final priority, «the whole is greater than the part», turns to concrete social reality today stating, «an innate tension also exists between globalization and localization». It proposes that we both pay attention to the global «so as to avoid narrowness and banality» and to the local «which keeps our feet on the ground» [234].

¹² J.C. SCANNONE, «Papa Francesco e la teologia del popolo» (cf. nt. 2), 583-585. These principles are articulated in a somewhat cursory way in Chapter 4 of *Evangelii Gaudium*, making it easy to miss their significance. However, they appear regularly in comments made by the Pope. See: «Time initiates processes, and space crystallises them. God is in history, in the processes. We must not focus on occupying the spaces where power is exercised, but rather on starting long-run historical processes», in «Intervista del Direttore a Papa Francesco», *La Civiltà Cattolica* 164 (2013) III 449-477. A valuable research project would be to study the claim by Scannone that Bergoglio was developing his notion of these four principles since his time as Jesuit provincial, and to document instances of their use.

¹³ Earlier in the document, Pope Francis employs the metaphor of «taking over space» in a way that illuminates his brief reference in Chapter 4: «This insidious worldliness is evident in a number of attitudes which appear opposed, yet all have the same pretence of “taking over the space of the Church”. In some people we see an ostentatious preoccupation for the liturgy (etc.)». *Evangelii Gaudium* 95.

II. INDUCTIVE THEOLOGY IN LONERGAN AND DORAN

I now seek to bring the thought of Pope Francis into dialogue with that of Bernard Lonergan and Lonergan's disciple, Robert Doran, suggesting that that a theological method grounded in Lonergan's critical realism can provide a rigorous foundation for the vision outlined in *Evangelii Gaudium*¹⁴. I do this having highlighted two sets of contrasts. The first is the different approach to culture held theologians of the people and the liberation theologians of other Latin American theologians; the second concerns the difference between the relatively deductive approach of the Vatican during the 1990s and the inductive approach of the bishops of Latin America, above all as reasserted in *Aparecida*.

1. *The Early Lonergan*

Early in Lonergan's career we see that he held some fundamental concerns in common with those that would preoccupy both Jorge Bergoglio and the Argentinian theologians who influenced him. These included making an option for the poor and conceiving a desire to help the Church engage in historically transformative action. At a more academic level, they included conceiving a desire to emerge from a deductive approach to reasoning to one that is more inductive and an intuition that this would facilitate helping the Church to engage in effective action in history.

Lonergan was born in 1904 in Buckingham, Quebec. After attending a Jesuit high-school in Montreal he joined the order at the age of seventeen. As part of his training for priesthood, he was sent to England for philosophy. During these years he found himself unimpressed by the manualist, Suarezian, neo-scholastic, philosophy that he was being offered. He began to search for a way to develop his own approach to philosophy and turned to a series of guides, among whom John Henry Newman and St. Augustine of Hippo were prominent. Both of these encouraged Lonergan to adopt an introspective approach to studying the process of knowing and deciding. In 1934 Lonergan was sent to the Gregorian University in Rome for his studies in theology and there felt an attraction to modern, historical-critical, methods of

¹⁴ Relating Lonergan to a theology of the people is not an entirely new idea. Scannone has made regular mention of Lonergan over his long career (starting with a book review of Lonergan's *Insight* in 1959). However, Scannone's own thought gives greater prominence to authors such as Blondel, Ricoeur, and Levinas. See, J.C. SCANNONE, «La Filosofia del Popolo», *La Civiltà Cattolica* 164 (2013) IV 105-120. See also Scannone's less than fully laudatory account of Lonergan: J.C. SCANNONE, «Afectividad y método, la conversión afectiva en la teoría del método de B. Lonergan», *Stromata* 65 (2009) 173-186. I suggest that many of the concerns expressed in this latter article are met when one adds Doran's thought to Lonergan.

studying Thomas Aquinas and became convinced that «the current interpretation of Aquinas is a consistent misinterpretation». He began to relate Newman and Augustine's approach to introspection to Aquinas's statement, «we know by what we are». He also related this line of thinking to «the turn to the subject» of René Descartes and made a personal breakthrough to his own «intellectual conversion» around 1935. From this time onwards, inviting others to engage in this conversion would be a centerpiece of his writings. He suggests that it involves acknowledging oneself to be a knower who must always engage in a process of three cognitional levels, characterized by «experience», «understanding», and «judgment»¹⁵.

He was eager to contrast his epistemology with the neo-scholasticism that prevailed in Catholic seminaries and suggested that such an approach involved a misunderstanding of Aquinas and a mistaken belief that truth can be known in some kind of instantaneous way by «taking a good look» at an object¹⁶.

If Lonergan's mind had a natural philosophical bent, he also developed, from an early stage, a concern for the poor and for social justice. A key moment here was 1930 when, after completing his studies in philosophy in England he was sent to be a teacher in the Jesuit High School in Montreal, where he himself had been educated. He arrived in the city in 1930 just as the effects of the Great Depression were beginning to be felt and he was shocked to witness people he knew falling into severe poverty. He recognized that that this economic depression, and the Wall Street Crash that preceded it, had origins in faulty thinking about the economy and on poor policy-making by politicians. He became convinced that modern civilization had need of Christian values that would extend to epistemological questions underlying the social sciences. He recalled a philosophy lecturer he had had in England, Lewis Watt SJ, who had built on the encyclical letter *Rerum Novarum* of

¹⁵ Principle sources for studying the intellectual development of the early Lonergan are R.M. LIDDY, *Transforming Light. Intellectual Conversion in the Early Lonergan*, Collegeville (MN) 1993; F. CROWE, *Lonergan*, Collegeville (MN) 1992 (translation in Italian available); W. MATTHEWS, *Lonergan's Quest. A Study of Desire in the Authoring of Insight*, Toronto 2005; and M. SHUTE, *The Origins of Lonergan's Notion of the Dialectic of History. A Study of Lonergan's Early Writings on History*, Lanham (Maryland) 1993.

¹⁶ Writing in the mid-1940's, Lonergan would make his criticism of Suarezian philosophy precise. He suggested that the cognitional theory of Aquinas described first a forming of a phantasm in the mind based on sense experience, then an insight into phantasm which produces an «inner word» in the form of a concept, and then a further step of «reduction ad principium» by which the mind checks the truth or falsity of the concept and terminates in an act of judgment. By contrast, Lonergan suggest that neo-scholastics had come to confuse the cognitional theory of Dun Scotus (1266-1308) with that of Aquinas: «Scotus posits concepts first, then the apprehension of nexus between concepts [...] The Scotist rejection of insight into phantasm necessarily reduced the act of understanding to seeing a nexus between concepts». B. LONERGAN, *Verbum. Word and Idea in Aquinas*, CWL 2, Toronto 2005, 39, nt. 126.

Pope Leo XIII a lecture course on social ethics in which he suggested that there was a need for comprehensive alternative in Catholic thought to that of Karl Marx. Watt proposed that this alternative should imitate Marx by producing, first, a philosophy of history, and, second, a theory of economics. From 1930 onwards Lonergan felt a deep committed to undertaking this project.

In 1933, Lonergan was sent to study theology at the Pontifical Gregorian University in Rome, with view to preparing him to become a lecturer there. For the most part, he was as unimpressed by his Suarezian theology lecturers there as he had been by their philosophical counterparts in England. However, in his private time he conducted an intense parallel course of reading and writing. This included formulating a series of draft versions of a philosophy of history, in line with that for which Watt had called. Here a basic intuition guided him: that the ideas concerning an epistemology based on intellectual conversion were of direct relevance for a philosophy of history. At an epistemological level, he recognized that knowing involved a process of passing through steps of attending to data, gaining insight, and affirming these insights in an act of judgment. He now recognized that this was an intrinsically time-bound process and that it applied just as much to human communities as to individuals. Next, his theological studies helped him to reflect on the realities both of human sinfulness and of how God's grace «heals nature». This prompted him to develop a theory of history based on a three-fold set of anticipatory, or «heuristic» concepts: «progress», «decline», and «redemption».

In these essays, Lonergan describes progress as the sequence of events in history that would occur if communities consistently made good decisions in terms of technological discovery, as well as the necessary changes in economics, politics, and culture that necessarily follow from this. By contrast, he speaks of «decline» as the deviation from the flow of progress caused by stupid and irresponsible decision-making. Finally, switching to a theological reflection on the fact that God has intervened in history, he speaks of «redemption», or «a supernatural dialectic», as present in all situations, suggesting that «Christ is the first mover of the tradition of grace» and adding, «The supernatural dialectic is the restoration of nature in face of the dialectic of sin»¹⁷. In subsequent years, Lonergan would do much to deepen his understanding of these three heuristic categories. However, as one commentator suggests of his essays of the 1930's: «The end result represents a permanent and fundamental achievement of Lonergan's thought during the period of his study at Rome»¹⁸.

¹⁷ M. SHUTE, *The Origins of Lonergan's Notion of the Dialectic of History* (cf. nt. 15), 127.

¹⁸ M. SHUTE, *The Origins of Lonergan's Notion of the Dialectic of History* (cf. nt. 15), 167.

Loneragan was so attached to dedicating himself to the vision of Lewis Watt that he wrote two letters to his provincial superior during the late 1930's asking he asked to be given the freedom to dedicate himself to Watt's project¹⁹. In one sense, plans to make him a theology professor did not seem compatible with this. However, Lonergan would later come to believe that the decision to assign him to this task was providential, as it helped him to develop the vision of Watt in important ways. Another complicating factor in how the events of his life unfolded was the outbreak of World War II, which compelled him to return to Canada, from where he would not return to Rome until 1954. In Canada, a relatively light work-load gave him the freedom to develop and pursue his main academic interests. This included researching for and writing an extensive manuscript on macroeconomics. However, late in the 1940s he became convinced that he would best devote his energies to the project of developing foundational reflections that should best employ his talents by developing foundational philosophical reflections that would be relevant to the broad philosophy of history that he had developed ten years earlier. This project culminated in his authoring the first of his two master-works: *Insight. A Study of Human Understanding* (1957)²⁰.

In *Insight*, Lonergan developed two key insights that had already emerged for him in the 1930s: that philosophy should hinge on an act of intellectual conversion by each philosopher; and that a metaphysics emerging from this epistemological event could be employed to develop a philosophy of history so as to exercise a wise «control over history». The first half of *Insight* is dedicated to inviting readers to perform an act of intellectual conversion. He then proposes a transition to metaphysics by suggesting suggests that by this act readers can affirm that they possess a «pure desire to know» that unfolds through three cognitional levels and which culminates in their knowing being. Next he suggests that there exists an «isomorphism», or parallelism of structure, between the structure of our knowing and the structure of being. Above all, he suggests that both these have a dynamic quality:

It is not only our notion of being that is heuristic, that heads for an objective that can be defined only in terms of the process of knowing it, but also the reality of proportionate being itself exhibits a similar incompleteness and a similar dynamic orientation [...] the objective universe is not at rest, not static, not fixed in the present, but in process, in tension, fluid²¹.

Such metaphysics of «dynamic orientation» has obvious overlaps with the theory of evolution of Charles Darwin. However, when Lonergan advances to

¹⁹ R.M. LIDDY, *Transforming Light* (cf. nt. 15), 107-110.

²⁰ B. LONERGAN, *Insight. A Study of Human Understanding*, in E. FREDERICK – F. CROWE – R.M. DORAN, ed., CWL 3, Toronto 1992.

²¹ B. LONERGAN, *Insight* (cf. nt. 20), 470.

speak about the human level of being, he applies his notion of emergent probability to a heuristic theory of history and its notions of progress, decline, and redemption. In this analysis, he suggests that it is of the greatest importance in the modern world that a culture should emerge that acknowledges the importance of intellectual conversion. He suggests that such a culture would support the notion that «man can discover emergent probability», and so seek to exercise a responsible «control over human history»²². He is not naïve about the chances of this culture actually emerging, but states, nevertheless:

Unfortunately, as insight and oversight commonly are mated, so also are progress and decline [...] But the very advance of knowledge brings a power over nature and over men too vast and terrifying to be entrusted to the good intentions of unconsciously biased minds. We have to learn to distinguish sharply between progress and decline, learn to encourage progress without putting a premium upon decline, learn to remove the tumour of the flight from understanding without destroying the organs of intelligence. No problem is at once more delicate and more profound, more practical and perhaps more pressing²³.

At the end of *Insight*, he applies his notion of emergent probability to a notion of a «vector» of redemption in history. However, given the fact that this is a work in philosophy, he leaves until later the project of reflecting more thoroughly on this.

The manner in which these concerns of the younger Lonergan converge with those of Pope Francis can be highlighted by relating Lonergan's heuristic theory of history to the four priorities for peace-making mentioned in Chapter 4 of *Evangelii Gaudium*. The desire of the young Lonergan to disengage from conceptualist Suarezianism converges with Pope Francis's statement «realities are more important than ideas», and his explanation, «Ideas — conceptual elaborations — are at the service of communication, understanding, and praxis» [232]. Similarly, I suggest that Lonergan's notion of progress and decline offer an explanatory underpinning for the Pope's metaphors in the statement, «Time is more important than space». I suggest that the Pope's metaphor of time implies a cognitional theory of knowing as a process, and a notion of progress that facilitates «processes of people-building» [224]. Similarly, I suggest that the metaphor of opting for space instead of time implies what Lonergan explains as decline. Pope Francis describes in terms of «opting for space» the phenomenon of individuals short-circuiting the process of authentic decision-making and opting instead for actions which both fail to serve the common good and, conveniently, serve their own interests [95]. Finally, I suggest that when the Pope suggests that «unity prevails

²² B. LONERGAN, *Insight* (cf. nt. 20), 252-253.

²³ B. LONERGAN, *Insight* (cf. nt. 20), 8.

over conflict», he is touching on matters that Lonergan explains in terms of the redemption that reverses decline and promotes progress.

2. *The Later Lonergan*

Some commentators suggest that Lonergan's second and final masterwork, *Method in Theology* (1972)²⁴ can be considered as a second volume of a project begun in *Insight*. They suggest that this book explores how theology can serve in directing the practice of religion to be a catalyst of redemption in history and so complements *Insight*, whose strength lay in analyzing progress and decline. For the most part I agree with this proposal²⁵, and I suggest that the manner in which Lonergan deepens his reflection on redemption in history provides further overlaps with the thought of Pope Francis. Above all, I suggest that it offers support for the principle, so distinctive of Argentinian theology, that in order to promote a just society one must first conduct an «evangelization of culture».

In 1954 Lonergan moved from Canada back to Rome where he would lecture theology at the Gregorian University until 1965. Upon arrival, he began to read extensively in existentialist, phenomenological, and hermeneutical philosophy and explored also of the manner in which historical and exegetical studies were beginning to transform theology. One effect of this reading was that he now began speaking not of «cognitive levels» but «levels of consciousness». This more accurate terminology helped him gain the insight that he should be speaking of four levels and not three²⁶.

Lonergan suggests that a first moment in the fourth level of consciousness involves experiencing an affective response to the values that are to be discerned as relevant to a situation that we have just affirmed at the third level of consciousness. He suggests that we, relatively spontaneously, recognize values as existing in a scale, or hierarchy, and that we feel drawn to sacrifice lower values in favour of higher values:

²⁴ B. LONERGAN, *Method in Theology*, Toronto 1972.

²⁵ Frederick Crowe suggests that *Insight* and *Method in Theology* can be understood as providing the kind of post-Aristotelian *novum organon* called for by the philosopher Francis Bacon in 1620: «Lonergan's achievement was to construct the new *organon* that [...] would be relevant to any human studies that investigated a cultural past to guide its future». F. CROWE, *Lonergan* (cf. nt. 15), 105-106. My own analysis suggests that one needs to add to these books the work of R. DORAN, *Theology and the Dialectics of History*, Toronto, 1990, in order to more-or-less complete the *novum organon*.

²⁶ Lonergan's fourth level of consciousness, characterized by decision, owes much to his reading of existentialist authors. Three series of lecture notes, published as books in the «Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan» (= CWL), capture Lonergan's incorporation of existentialist and hermeneutical thought in transition between *Insight* and *Method in Theology*. *Phenomenology and Logic*, CWL 18, Toronto 2001; *Topics in Education*, CWL 10, Toronto 1993; and *Understanding and Being*, CWL 5, Toronto 1990.

Not only do feelings respond to values. They do so in accord with some scale of preference. So we may distinguish vital, social, cultural, personal, and religious values in an ascending order. Vital values, such as health and strength, grace and vigour, normally are preferred to avoiding the work, privations, pains involved in acquiring, maintaining, restoring them. Social values, such as the good of order which conditions the vital values of individual members of the community [...] Cultural values do not exist without the underpinning of vital and social values, but none the less they rank higher. Not on bread alone doth man live. Over and above mere living and operating, men have to find a meaning and value in their living and operating. It is the function of culture to discover, express, validate, criticize, correct, develop, improve such meaning and value. Personal value is the person in his self-transcendence, as loving and being loved, as originator of values in himself and in his milieu, as an inspiration and invitation to others to do likewise. Religious values, finally, are at the heart of the meaning and value of man's living and man's world²⁷.

He suggests that we next move beyond a mere affective response to value is to make a judgment of value, i.e. to judge what kind of value is really and truly at stake in the situation we are evaluating. He then suggests that our next step is to make a decision to act. Throughout these activities of the fourth level of consciousness, he suggest that there is a drive within us that moves us forward that is a new manifestation the same drive to self-transcendence that manifests itself at earlier levels of consciousness as a pure desire to know and a notion of being. He speaks of this drive as a «transcendental notion of value»²⁸.

This reflection on value, affectivity, and our «transcendental intending» next opens up theological questions for Lonergan. Now he begins to speak of

²⁷ B. LONERGAN, *Method in Theology* (cf. nt. 24), 31-32. In another account of this scale of values Lonergan explains each level as follows: «Vital values of health and strength; with the social values enshrined in family and custom, society and education, the state and the law, the economy and technology, the church or sect; with the cultural values of religion and art, language and literature, science, philosophy, history, theology; with the achieved personal value of one dedicated to realizing values in himself and promoting their realization in others». See, B. LONERGAN, «The Response of the Jesuit as Priest and Apostle in the Modern World», in *Collection*, CWL 4, Toronto 1988, 168-169.

²⁸ Central to Lonergan's account of the fourth level of consciousness is an account of «transcendental notion of value» that drives us to both recognize and to do the good. Following a Thomistic tradition of asserting «we know [and do] by what we are» he asserts that our notion of value involves a limited participation in the goodness of God himself: «The transcendentals are contained in questions prior to the answers. They are the radical intending that moves us from ignorance to knowledge [...] they intend the unknown whole or totality of which our answers reveal only part». B. LONERGAN, *Method in Theology* (cf. nt. 24), 11-12. In speaking of the fourth level of consciousness, Lonergan acknowledged that he owed much to philosophers such as Husserl, Heidegger and Dilthey. However, he also suggested that none of them quite completed the process of introspection so far as to affirm the existence of a notion of being and a notion of value. As a result, he suggested, they remained at the level of relativism. See, B. LONERGAN, *Phenomenology and Logic* (cf. nt. 26), 264-265. 310-311.

the possibility of a «religious conversion». He suggests that love is a key value that we experience and first describes this in natural expressions: «the love of intimacy of husband and wife» and «the patriotic love of one's community and nation». Then, he suggests that something of surpassing importance occurs when our open-ended desire for transcendence at an affective level meets with an offer of self-giving love by God. Quoting St Paul's letter to Romans (5:5), he describes a moment when we can experience «God's love flooding our hearts through the Holy Spirit, given to us»²⁹. He further asserts: «Being in love with God, as experienced, is being in love in an unrestricted fashion. All love is self-surrender, but being in love with God is being in love without limits or qualifications or conditions or reservations»³⁰. Exploring the supernatural quality of this experience, he suggests that it:

dismantles and abolishes the horizon in which our knowing and choosing went on and it sets up a new horizon in which the love of God will transvalue our values and the eyes of that love will transform our knowing. Though not the product of our knowing and choosing, it is a conscious dynamic state of love, joy, peace, that manifests itself in acts of kindness, goodness, fidelity, gentleness, and self-control (Gal 5, 22)³¹.

This quotation represents the «transposition» into the terminology of intentionality analysis of the Thomistic principle that God's grace supernaturally «elevates» nature. However, by mentioning that God «transvalues our values» he is also offering a transposition of the Thomist principle that grace «heals» nature. Elaborating on this latter point, Lonergan speaks of how religious conversion stimulates a «moral conversion» which «changes the criterion of one's decisions and choices from satisfactions to values»³². He explains in the light of religious conversion, which has intensified our ability to respond to the highest value, religious value, we recognize that we have been habitually been responding only to lower values. Now, he suggests, in an act of moral conversion we find ourselves able to decide to respond to the entire scale, being ready to sacrifice lower values for higher.

Repeating the procedure followed in *Insight*, Lonergan advances from an analysis of individual conscious intentionality to an account of community life and its history. A first step here is to note that «social institutions and human cultures have meanings as intrinsic components». He adds, «The family, the state, the law, the economy are not fixed and immutable entities. They adapt to changing circumstances; they can be reconceived in the light of

²⁹ B. LONERGAN, *Method in Theology* (cf. nt. 24), 105.

³⁰ B. LONERGAN, *Method in Theology* (cf. nt. 24), 105-106.

³¹ B. LONERGAN, *Method in Theology* (cf. nt. 24), 106.

³² B. LONERGAN, *Method in Theology* (cf. nt. 24), 240.

new ideas»³³. Next, he speaks of religious communities as being constituted by meanings that emerge from an experience of religious conversion. He then speaks of how theology first helps a religious community articulate its own religious meanings so that they become constitutive of its own way of life. Next, however, he speaks of how religion has the task of mediating redemptive meanings to society at large, including to those who not share the religious faith of the theologian. He then proposes that the theologian speaks more directly of reversing decline and promoting progress, without going into details of just where his or her energy comes from to be so clear on these issues.

In *Method in Theology* Lonergan articulates a proposal for theological method that is based on his notions of religious, moral, and intellectual conversion. He speaks of how «Theology mediates between a cultural matrix and the significance and role of a religion within that matrix»³⁴. He speaks of different theologians collaborating in a series of «functional specializations» that involve two phases: the first that retrieves a tradition, and the second that mediates it to a current culture. He explains each phase as constituted by four functional specialties, with each specialty witnessing especially to the importance of one of the levels of consciousness³⁵. He calls the final, eighth, functional specialty is called «communications» and states that this is the moment where theology «bears fruit» in assisting a religious community to communicate redemptive meanings and values both to itself and to the culture in which it finds itself. In the ministry of communicating redemptive meanings to culture, he suggests that theology should seek to build on those aspects of culture that already constitute a dimension of progress:

The Christian message is to be communicated to all nations. Such communication presupposes that preachers and teachers enlarge their horizons to include an accurate and intimate understanding of the culture and the language of the people they address. They must grasp the virtual resources of that culture and that language, and they must use those virtual resources creatively so that the Christian message becomes, not disruptive of the culture, not an alien patch superimposed upon it, but a line of development within the culture³⁶.

After Lonergan had published *Method in Theology*, he continued to deepen his reflection on how religious conversion functions both in healing individual consciousness and how theology can help a religious community engage in healing history. Returning to his analysis of the scale of values, he introduces a terminology of «two ways of development», constituted by «devel-

³³ B. LONERGAN, *Method in Theology* (cf. nt. 24), 78-79.

³⁴ B. LONERGAN, *Method in Theology* (cf. nt. 24), Introduction, XI.

³⁵ An overview of the functional specialties is offered in B. LONERGAN, *Method in Theology* (cf. nt. 24), 125-144.

³⁶ B. LONERGAN, *Method in Theology* (cf. nt. 24), 362.

opment from below», and «development from above». He applies the metaphor of development from below to much of what he had been exploring in works like *Insight*, where he had outlined the process of advancing «from experience to growing understanding, from growing understanding to balanced judgment, from balanced judgment to fruitful courses of action»³⁷. Similarly, he applies the metaphor of development from below to much of what he had previously stated concerning both progress and decline in history. Next, however, he begins to employ the metaphor «development from above» to describe the process of individual healing and redemption in history. Noting how religious conversion easily prompts a transformation of personal values in an act of moral conversion he begins to speak of how this process «from above» proceeds to heal first our capacity to respond to cultural values and then to social values. Turning to the historical question of how theologians operating in the functional specialty of communications can exercise a redemptive influence on history, he is more clear than before that this must focus first on a ministry to culture so that, by this means, communities may be persuaded to change social structures so that they return to the way of genuine progress. In an article entitled, «Healing and Creating in History», he states:

I have spoken of creating in history [progress] and of its nemesis [decline]. But my topic also calls for a few words on healing [...] there [...] is development from above downwards [...] There is the transformation of falling in love: the domestic love of family. The human love of one's tribe one's city, one's country, mankind; the divine love that orientates man in his cosmos and expresses itself in his worship. Here hatred only sees evil, love reveals values [...] love breaks the bonds of psychological and social determinisms with the conviction of faith and the power of hope³⁸.

In an article written toward the end of his life, «Theology and Praxis», Lonergan relates his notion of development from above to theological debates occurring in the 1970's³⁹. This article opens with a comment on the difference between two notions of the term praxis, one with which he agrees, and one with which he does not. He notes that many theologians at the time of writing speak about the need for a «praxis» that would change history by direct efforts to change social structures. He expresses his disapproval of the notion of praxis at work here, and suggests that, at least implicitly, it seeks to impose solutions on society by force, rather than by persuasion. By contrast, he appeals to a second notion of praxis, one that is closer to the original use of the term in ancient Greek philosophy. These philosophers spoke of the

³⁷ B. LONERGAN, «Healing and Creating in History», in F.E. CROWE, ed., *A Third Collection. Papers By Bernard J.F. Lonergan*, Mahwah (NJ) 1985, 106.

³⁸ B. LONERGAN, «Healing and Creating in History» (cf. nt. 37), 106.

³⁹ B. LONERGAN, «Theology as Praxis», in *A Third Collection* (cf. nt. 37), 184-201.

«praxis» of becoming a virtuous person who can make just decisions. He compares this notion to his own explanation of the importance of religious, moral, and intellectual conversion, and of the importance of promoting a culture that recognizes the value of these conversions. He concludes «To ask whether theology is a praxis in this second sense [...] is to ask [...] whether there are basic theological questions whose solution depends on the personal development of theologians»⁴⁰. His point here is that theologians engaging in the humbling process of letting God's grace heal them «from above» are best suited to recognize how a healing from above must occur in society — by means of communicating redemptive meanings to culture — in order that true justice might prevail.

Recalling the debates between an Argentinian theology of «socio-cultural mediation» and alternative Latin American theologies of «socio-economic mediation», it is clear where Lonergan would stand. Indeed, I suggest that Lonergan's notion of theology promoting a development from above in history provides a solid explanatory foundation for what a theology of the people was seeking to express when it stressed the importance of evangelizing culture. It seems to me to be important to recall Scannone's suggestion that a contributing factor to the distinctiveness of a theology of the people was that the Argentinian Church had the advantage of being able to draw on a wider range of Catholic academics that was the case in other Latin American countries. I note that these academics included anthropologists and hermeneutical philosophers — individuals who were experts in exactly the fields in which Lonergan began to read as he prepared to write *Method in Theology*. I suggest that the over-simplified social analysis of certain theologians in the 1970s, such as Juan Luis Segundo, was at least in part the result of the absence of qualified collaborators who could help them to deepen and moderate a simplistic reliance on Marxist analysis.

3. Robert Doran

By the time died, in 1984, a number of aspects of Lonergan's thought remained insufficiently developed. Robert Doran, his disciple and fellow Jesuit (born in 1939), sought to develop some of these that related directly to the concern for social justice that had directed Lonergan's interests for most of his career⁴¹. From the point of view of comparisons with the thought of Pope Francis, Doran's major work *Theology and the Dialectics of History* (1990), makes key contributions on three themes: how to understand the notion of a preferential option for the poor; how to relate the inductive

⁴⁰ B. LONERGAN, «Theology as Praxis» (cf. nt. 39), 185.

⁴¹ Exploring this point is a central thesis of my book: G. WHELAN, *Redeeming History. Social Concern in Bernard Lonergan and Robert Doran*, Rome 2013.

method of «See, Judge, Act» to Lonergan's functional specialties; and the importance of popular piety in attempts to evangelize culture.

Before outlining Doran's position on a preferential option for the poor, it is important to recognize the way in which he first expands upon Lonergan's most foundational thought. At the level of the invitation to self-appropriation, he explores the manner in which the realm of the unconscious motivation impinges upon our conscious functioning, or, as he puts it the way our «psyche» interacts with our «self-transcending spirit». Drawing on modern psychoanalysis, he suggests that the intellectually converted individual must learn to pay careful attention to his or her psyche and how it facilitates or blocks the self-transcendence of spirit. In this respect, he suggests that we speak of an additional conversion to those identified by Lonergan: «psychic conversion». He suggests that one result of adding this conversion will be an ability to understand how symbol and an orientation to beauty functions in consciousness, because these issues appertain more to the life of the psyche than to the intellect. Similarly, based on this broader notion of conversion, Doran produces an expanded version of Lonergan's theory of history. In this context he suggests that, as the Church reflects on issues that are important to its mission in the world today, «perhaps none is more urgent at the present time than those raised by the theology of liberation».

As mentioned above, he makes important contributions to three issues relevant to liberation theology, the first of which is an explanation of an preferential option for the poor. On this matter he appeals to Lonergan's notion of the scale of values and the notion of development from above that stems from this:

Our position on the scale of values constitutes in effect a defense from the standpoint of a transcendental anthropology of the insights of theologians of liberation regarding, first, the hermeneutically privileged position for theology of the most grievously victimized peoples of our globe and, second, the preferential option for the poor that most govern the church's exercise of all its ministry⁴².

In one sense, Doran's suggestion involves only a small addition to Lonergan: that our religious conversion can prompt an immediate concern for the fact that the poor are excluded from enjoying the vital goods of society. Consequently, having felt a new ability to respond to religious values — which are at the top of the scale of values — we feel an immediate concern with questions of vital values — which are at the bottom of the scale. Of course, the vital values in question are not those we enjoy ourselves but those from which the poor are systematically excluded. At a superficial level, one can state that Doran simply adds to Lonergan the suggestion that in our development from above, our commitment to healing cultural and social

⁴² R. DORAN, *Theology and the Dialectics of History* (cf. nt. 25), 423; see also, 12.

values in society can receive an added sense of urgency because of this concern for the vital needs of others. However, in another sense, Doran's explanation of this concern involves a rich expansion on Lonergan's account of affectivity, the scale of values, the dynamics of history, and the nature of Christian mission⁴³.

In explaining how religious conversion initiates a development from above in consciousness, Doran draws on the thought of Karl Jung to explore how God's grace touches both our conscious and unconscious minds. He employs a notion of «victimization» to explain how difficult it can be for individuals to allow unconscious woundedness to be healed. Employing a vocabulary of «complexes» and «defence mechanisms» he suggests: «The freedom to deal compassionately with our own darkness must be given to us. We cannot find that freedom in the creative vector of our own consciousness»⁴⁴. He then suggests, «Healing will frequently be mediated precisely in and through the suffering of the lover due to the darkness of the beloved»⁴⁵ and adds that the symbol *par excellence* of a readiness to suffer for others is the cross of Jesus Christ. He suggests that it is only because of the divine intervention in history, completed in the self-sacrificing act of Jesus Christ (and the resurrection that followed it), that our damaged psyches find healing. He suggests that Christians who are relating positively to the symbol of the cross find them drawn to show a similar kind of love to others by showing a «participation in the specifically paschal dimension of “what Jesus did”»⁴⁶.

Doran next suggests that as we begin experience an increased alertness to and empathy with the suffering of others we can become sensitive to the fact that whole categories of people — the poor — are excluded from enjoying the vital goods of society, and that this can prompt us to decide to direct our actions motivated by a «preferential option for the poor». He adds that for many people this option will first be expressed with respect to individuals with whom one comes into direct contact. However, he adds that when such a spontaneous concern is combined with an intelligent understanding of modern society, a preferential option for the poor can extend to a commitment to change the social structures that exclude these people from an enjoy-

⁴³ As already indicated in nt. 14, above, I suggest that Doran's account of affectivity, an option for the poor, and the situation as source of theology go a long way to meet Scannone's criticisms of Lonergan in: J.C. SCANNONE, «Afectividad y método, la conversión afectiva en la teoría del método de B. Lonergan», *Stromata* 65 (2009) 173-186.

⁴⁴ J.C. SCANNONE, «Afectividad y método» (cf. nt. 43), 241-242.

⁴⁵ J.C. SCANNONE, «Afectividad y método» (cf. nt. 43), 243-244.

⁴⁶ J.C. SCANNONE, «Afectividad y método» (cf. nt. 43), 121-122. In an argument somewhat like that of Karl Rahner's «anonymous Christian» Doran suggests that the grace of Christ can be working even in those who do not consciously know it. This has obvious implications for a theology of religions. However, Doran adds that because of the effectiveness of the symbol of the Cross, «Christianity has some genuine universal significance». J.C. SCANNONE, «Afectividad y método» (cf. nt. 43), 108.

ment of vital goods. Finally, he suggests that, intellectual conversion helps us to understand how cultural values are related to social values and to channel our option for the poor into seeking to evangelize culture. On this issue, he understands theology to be of the greatest importance:

It remains true that theology's direct task of evocation, after its ecclesial function, is with respect to a new set of cultural values [...] but because of the relations of the levels of value from below upwards, we can see that these cultural values are called for precisely because of the global distortions at the more basic levels of value, and that they must be proportionate to the demands of the underlying social dialectic⁴⁷.

Doran suggests that anchoring a notion of option for the poor in a transcendental anthropology helps to distinguish it, definitively, from Marxist notions of opting for revolutionary praxis. Equally, he states that it should help to persuade theologians from all continents that allocating a hermeneutical privilege to «the most grievously victimized peoples of our globe» is not an optional extra in theology.

A second innovation of Doran's thought over that of Lonergan concerns his insights into what he calls «the situation as source of theology». I suggest that this assists reflection on how Lonergan's notion of theological method converges with those who advocate a «See, Judge, Act» method in theology⁴⁸. The «See, Judge, Act» method implies an attentiveness to context that was not absent from Lonergan. However, it is left strangely underdeveloped in *Method in Theology*. In the end, one can receive the impression that Lonergan's notion of theological method involves a one-way process of retrieving a tradition and formulating its insights so as to make it understood within a culture. What seems neglected is a direction of influence in the other direction. Doran stresses that it is not Lonergan's intention to deny such an influence. He points out that Lonergan's explanation of the function of theology employs a notion of «mediation» that implies a two-directional interaction: «Theology mediates between a cultural matrix and the significance and role of a religious tradition within that matrix». Equally, Doran points out that when Lonergan arrives at an explanation of his eighth functional specialty, «communications», he speaks of relation of a «reciprocal dependence» existing between this and the prior functional specialties. However, he acknowledges that Lonergan fails to develop this point and suggests that this

⁴⁷ J.C. SCANNONE, «Afectividad y método» (cf. nt. 43), 423.

⁴⁸ In the Introduction to *Theology and Dialectics of History*, Doran indicates that he adds certain «emphases» not found in Lonergan's thought and adds: «The most obvious of these emphases lies in the assertion that the situation which a theology addresses is as much a source of theology as are the data provided by the Christian tradition». R. DORAN, *Theology and the Dialectics of History* (cf. nt. 25), 8. He explores this point further in R. DORAN, *What is Systematic Theology?*, Toronto 2005.

is a significant weakness in *Method in Theology*. He attempts to supply for this weakness by reflecting explicitly on how ideas and values derived from a study of context (not least the needs of the poor) can influence the manner in which one retrieves a tradition and reflects systematically upon it. In terms of the vocabulary of functional specialization, this implies that questions arising from communications, should determine how we proceed in all previous functional specialties, not least the seventh one, «systematics».

By way of explaining this point, Doran moves briefly beyond the methodical reflection that is the purpose of the *Theology and the Dialectics of History* to engage directly in a systematic theology that demonstrates how the situation can be a source for systematic theology. He suggests that culture today is characterized by a process of globalization in which can be recognized both dimensions of decline and progress. The former, he describes as an attitude of «Post-historical humanity» which «would [...] lock our psyches and imaginations and questioning spirit into ever more rigid straitjackets»; the latter he describes as a movement toward a «World-cultural humanity» which «would entail the building of a crosscultural communitarian alternative»⁴⁹. Speaking of the redemptive mission of the Church he adds:

Love alone releases one to be creatively self-transcendent [...] such is the atmosphere that must permeate the crosscultural communitarian alternative to all forms of oppression [...] with which we must contend in the present situation addressed by a contemporary Christian theology⁵⁰.

Comparing Doran's analysis to the notion of theology that is based on an «inductive» method of «See, Judge, Act», we recognized many parallels. The moment of «See», would involve a study of the situation employing categories of progress, decline, and redemption, both at the level of culture and of social structures; the moment of «Judge» would involve the collaborative process of employing the first seven functional specialties to articulate the significance and role of a religious tradition within the situation that has just been analyzed; and, finally, the moment of «Act» would involve conducting of the eighth functional specialty, «communications», which would plan and carry out effective strategies of communicating redemptive meanings and values to a situation⁵¹.

A third and final area of convergence between the thought of Doran and that of Pope Francis lies on the question of the importance of respecting popular piety in pastoral practice. On this issue, Doran suggests that we expand upon Lonergan's notion of culture and cultural values. He suggests

⁴⁹ R. DORAN, *Theology and the Dialectics of History* (cf. nt. 25), 37.

⁵⁰ R. DORAN, *Theology and the Dialectics of History* (cf. nt. 25), 41.

⁵¹ Strikingly, Pope Francis conducts a brief but similar analysis of globalization and an appropriate Christian response in his discussion of the principle of «the whole is greater than the part». *Evangelii Gaudium* 234.

that psychic conversion helps us to recognize how Lonergan's account of the scale of values is incomplete. He reminds us how much unconscious factors are at work in affectivity and suggests that our psyche and our «self-transcending spirit» respond differently to the same level of value. For example, he points out that at the level of social value, spirit responds to the dictates of practical reason, whereas the psyche responds to the tugs of intersubjective bonds. He notes that these attractions can pull in different directions, for example when intersubjectivity resists the new ideas proposed by practical intelligence because a new ordering of society that would follow would disrupt pre-existing intersubjective bonds. He suggests that decision-making that promotes progress will seek to find a golden mean between these two poles of social value⁵².

Similarly, when Doran turns to question of cultural value he suggests that there exists a duality in our response. Drawing on the thought of Eric Voegelin, he suggests that two foundational kinds of culture can be recognized in human societies. The first, «anthropological», culture is a relatively recent development in human history, being especially associated with the philosophy of Ancient Greece and the formation of European culture. He suggests that Lonergan offers an adequate account of anthropological notions of culture. By contrast, he suggests that «cosmological» culture has characterizes primal peoples from the beginnings of humanity and relies primarily on symbolic expression to communicate the ideas and values that constitute culture, a culture that stresses the continuity of human living with the cycles of nature⁵³. He suggests that Lonergan paid inadequate attention to this second pole of how we respond to cultural values. Indeed, he notes that an anthropological notion of culture is accentuated in modern and Western cultures at the expense of the cosmological, and suggests that this constitutes a dimension of decline in modern culture: «An exclusively anthropological determination of culture is productive of that distortion of the dialectic of culture that is internally constitutive of modern imperialism»⁵⁴. He adds that it is the mission of the Church to communicate redemptive — or «soteriological» — meanings and values to situations and that this should include an invitation to hold in balance anthropological and cosmological dimensions:

⁵² In fact, Doran is able to rely entirely on Lonergan's analysis of the «dialectic of community» in Chapter 7 of *Insight* for his analysis of the «dialectical» dimension of the social level of value. His original contribution will be in discussing the dialectical nature of our response to cultural value.

⁵³ «Cosmological truth is the discovery that direction in the movement of life lies in a harmony between human decisions and actions, on the one hand, and the rhythms and processes of nature, on the other hand, that is, in a synchronicity between culture and nature. Anthropological truth establishes by a more specialized reflection that the ultimate measure of human integrity is a reality beyond the cosmos». R. DORAN, *Theology and the Dialectics of History* (cf. nt. 25), 216.

⁵⁴ R. DORAN, *Theology and the Dialectics of History* (cf. nt. 25), 479.

The condition of the possibility of the relative integrity of the dialectic of community lies in genuine cultural values [...] the integral dialectic of cosmological and anthropological constitutive meaning, and so of culture, is itself a function of soteriological constitutive meaning as the latter is communicated through the ministry of the community that is the principle recipient of and witness to that revealed meaning and truth⁵⁵.

It should be obvious what compatibility exists between Doran's analysis and the stress placed by a theology of the people on the value of popular piety. Indeed one can appreciate how, in *Evangelii Gaudium*, Pope Francis adds a valuable insight to this line of thinking. The Pope suggests that, especially in developing countries, there is a tendency for different social classes to respond to values in different ways. He acknowledges that the educated middle classes may respond to expressions anthropological value in a way that gives it priority. By contrast, he suggests that the masses of the poor are likely to respond far more to cosmological expressions of value — which are always expressed more in symbolic form (e.g. devotions to Our Lady) — than in the form of clear and distinct ideas. Consequently, to attempt to make proposals for progress in society, and to produce proposals for Christian pastoral action in a way that failed to take account of the cosmological expression of values (or for that matter for intersubjective values at the social level of value) would be destructive⁵⁶.

III. SUMMARY AND CONCLUSION

In this paper, I have attempted to recognize the deeper currents of theological thinking that underlie *Evangelii Gaudium* and to suggest that the theological method of Lonergan and Doran can do much to promote the vision of Pope Francis.

In pursuing this point, I drew much on the analysis of Juan Carlos Scannone, another contributor to this issue of *Gregorianum*. I highlighted some aspects of what Scannone describes as an Argentinian theology of the people noting its major characteristics: a preferential option for the poor; the

⁵⁵ R. DORAN, *Theology and the Dialectics of History* (cf. nt. 25), 147.

⁵⁶ A striking convergence would also seem to exist between Doran's analysis of the dialectic of culture and comments made by Juan Carlos Scannone. He describes how he has collaborated with the philosopher and anthropologist Rodolfo Kusch to identify three distinct notions of being at work in Latin American culture. He suggests that these metaphysical notions are captured by three distinct Spanish verbs, «*ser*», «*estar*», and «*acontecer*». These seem to converge with Doran's notions of culture as (in the same order) «anthropological», «cosmological», and «soteriological». See, J.C. SCANNONE, «Una Filosofía del Povo», (cf. nt. 14), 110; and compare with R. DORAN, *Theology and the Dialectics of History* (cf. nt. 25), 473-526.

employing of the inductive method, «See, Judge, Act»; and an emphasis on the importance of an evangelization of culture. I also noted Scannone's claim that this theology exercised a significant influence on the young Jorge Bergoglio. Next, I traced how, over a series of decades, the theology of the people entered into an at times confrontational debate with two different approaches to theology: one represented by non-Argentinian liberation theologians; and the other represented by the Holy See during the pontificate of John Paul II. Next, I noted the role played by Cardinal Archbishop Jorge Bergoglio in the CELAM conference at Aparecida in 2007 and commented on the parallels between *Evangelii Gaudium* and the final document of that conference.

Turning to the thought of Lonergan and Doran on theological method, I suggested that there exist deep compatibilities between the thought of Pope Francis and these thinkers. Studying the early years of Lonergan's academic career, I suggested that the epistemology he developed, based on an invitation to «intellectual conversion», helps to offer a rigorous explanation of what is more descriptively called an «inductive» approach to knowing, an approach that pervades *Evangelii Gaudium*. Similarly, I noted how a concern for the poor was expressed by Lonergan in his applying this epistemology to a heuristic account of history based on notions of progress, decline, and redemption, notions that are compatible with the emphasis on the ongoing process of historical engagement to which Pope Francis calls Christians. Next, I outlined how the later Lonergan engaged with existentialist and hermeneutical philosophy and deepened his notion of how culture interacts with social structures. I suggested that his notion of theology assisting a «development from above» offers direct support for the Argentinian approach within Liberation theology that emphasizes the priority of an evangelizing of culture. In my discussion of the thought of Doran, I suggested that he developed themes that, while close to the heart of Lonergan, were left surprisingly underdeveloped by the time of Lonergan's death. I focused on three central themes in Doran's thought that deepen a convergence with the thought of Pope Francis: a preferential option for the poor; the situation as source for theology; and the importance of cosmological responses to cultural values (as expressed in popular piety).

In concluding these reflections, I would like to note that employing the theological method of Lonergan and Doran could help the Church to accept the deeper challenge implied by *Evangelii Gaudium*. It would help to avoid any tendency to dismiss the message of Pope Francis as «merely pastoral». By contrast with such an attitude, I suggest that *Evangelii Gaudium* constitutes for papal teaching what one commentator suggested was the significance of the Aparecida document for the teaching of the regional conference of Latin American Bishops: «a return to inductive theology». This having been said, I also suggest that the terminology inductive/deductive theology is

less than precise. Here I propose that the kernel of truth contained in this terminology is best articulated in terms of Lonergan's notion of functional specialization, especially as elaborated by Doran. Indeed, by grounding many of the key insights of a theology of the people in the fundamental structures of human consciousness, the thought of Lonergan and Doran can help it become less specifically Argentinian and more acceptable for an international audience.

On a related issue, this article has only painted broad brush-strokes for what could be a more sustained dialogue between Lonergan and Doran's thought and the proponents of a theology of the people. In fact, such a dialogue could be broadened to employ a Lonergan-based approach in relating a theology of the people to what are often called «contextual theologies» on different continents⁵⁷.

Pontificia Università Gregoriana
Piazza della Pilotta, 4
00187 Roma (Italia)
E-mail: whelan@unigre.it

Gerard WHELAN, S.I.

ABSTRACT

This article builds on the account offered by Juan Carlos Scannone of how the intellectual roots of Pope Francis lie in an Argentinian «theology of the people» and of how closely *Evangelii Gaudium* is related to the final document of the CELAM conference held at Aparecida, 2007, in which Cardinal Jorge Bergoglio was deeply involved. It proposes a mediation of Pope Francis's thought to guide the conduct of a global, academic, and «contextual» exercise in theology and suggests that the thought of Bernard Lonergan and Robert Doran can provide rigorous foundations for this mediation. It explores this point by studying themes that include: the conversion of the theologian, epistemology and history, an option for the poor, the evangelization of culture, the importance of popular piety, and the situation as source of theology.

Keywords: Conversion, epistemology, history, option for the poor, evangelization of culture, popular piety, sources of theology

⁵⁷ See, S. BEVANS, *Models of Contextual Theology*, Maryknoll (NY) 2002.

RIASSUNTO

Questo articolo si basa sulla relazione offerta da Juan Carlos Scannone, la quale mostra come le radici intellettuali di Papa Francesco si trovino in una «teologia del popolo» argentina e di quanto *Evangelii Gaudium* sia legato strettamente al documento finale della conferenza del CELAM ad Aparecida, 2007, in cui il cardinale Jorge Bergoglio è stato profondamente coinvolto. Propone una mediazione del pensiero di Papa Francesco per guidare la prassi di una teologia accademica, mondiale e «contestuale», e suggerisce che il pensiero di Bernard Lonergan e Robert Doran può fornire rigorosi fondamenti per questa mediazione. L'articolo esplora questo punto studiando temi d'interesse comune, tra cui: la conversione del teologo, l'epistemologia e la storia, l'opzione per i poveri, l'evangelizzazione della cultura, l'importanza della pietà popolare e la situazione, come fonte della teologia.

Parole chiave: conversione, epistemologia, storia, opzione per i poveri, evangelizzazione della cultura, pietà popolare, fonti della teologia